

"Democracies require the willingness to respect others' viewpoints and a capacity for compromise."

SON OF THE SOIL

His presence at various moments in the country's history has been critical in establishing conventions of governance and the virtues of consensus. The impartial institution of President is his lasting legacy.

■ By Salil Misra

Rajendra Prasad needs to be remembered for making three distinct and lasting contributions to Indian politics. He made these contributions in three different capacities during his long career—as a leader of the national movement, as president of the Constituent Assembly formed in 1946 to frame a Constitution for independent India, and as first President of the Indian republic. The impact made by him in

Rajendra Prasad

First President of India 1884-1963

all three capacities has left an important imprint on the political life of modern India.

Prasad came from an obscure village of north Bihar and earned the reputation of being an ardent follower of Mahatma Gandhi during the course of the national movement. It has been generally believed by many historians that he formed a very close political association with Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and C. Rajagopalachari. The triumvirate, called the Right-wing of the Congress, was known for a shared distaste and distrust for the Left-wing politics represented by Jawaharlal Nehru and Subhas Chandra Bose. The disagreements between the two groups over many matters of strategy and vision were well known. Prasad, however, took great care to ensure that the different positions did not

